



organisational goals rather than individual ones. But to accomplish it, the public official had to be socialised into his or her position—to view one's career as a vocation so that one gives one's working life to the organisation. In return for this sacrifice, the public official is assured security of tenure. Weber recognised that if the role of public administration was to regulate the capitalist market, then the underlying logic driving the bureaucracy had to be different from the interest-seeking logic of the market. Shielding the career of bureaucrats from their political and economic elite was a means of ensuring autonomy for them.

The Weberian bureaucracy—meritocratic, insulated from politics and social pressures, devoted to public interest, accountable and uncorrupt—has never existed in its pure form. For example, although advancement through the bureaucracy is expected to be meritocratic, most often it is based on length of service and political considerations. The political domination of the bureaucratic machine (through control over promotions and transfers) can lead it to favour political interests over public ones. The vision of bureaucracy as divorced from the social and cultural context was unlikely to exist in reality.

Hence, the creation of mechanisms for the easy dismissal of public officials. What might

Tainted trust: Gautam Goswami, former district magistrate of Patna and a key accused in the Rs 170-million Bihar flood relief scam, after his release from prison; (left) former central excise commissioner P. K. Ajwani, who was arrested by the CBI for misappropriation of wealth in 2004

Vote of No Confidence

CIVIL SOCIETY ORGANISATIONS NEED TO PLAY AN IMPORTANT PART IN BRINGING CASES OF MALPRACTICE TO LIGHT. NOT SURPRISINGLY, THE WORLD VALUES SURVEY 2005 SHOWS A CONTINUED DROP IN CITIZEN CONFIDENCE IN THE CIVIL SERVICES IN INDIA.

these mechanisms look like? First, it should be made clear that having a transparent and fair process for dismissing corrupt officials is not the same as downsizing government as part of neo-liberal reforms. Second, the process of firing bureaucrats should be kept out of the hands of politicians. Control over transfers and promotions by politicians have made public officials more responsive to political considerations than the rule of law. In a country where politicians are not part of the process of selecting candidates for public service, there is no reason for them to be part of the process of dismissing them. Instead, civil society organisations need to play an important part in bringing cases of malpractice to light. An independent investigating body with representation from various arenas including citizens and powers of dismissing public officials needs to be established, whose workings shall be transparent and open to inspection by the public.

Despite the problem of not having a watchdog for such reforms, one can't help but think: what are the chances of such a reform passing and a body to oversee dismissals being created? As we know with the difficulties experienced in passing the Women's Reservation Bill, those in power are reluctant to let it go. Those who benefit from the current system will oppose reforms. Only a groundswell of support from citizens and public debate is such a reform are likely to be on the agenda. There is a need to generate awareness in the long run, that such a reform can lead to a win-win situation for all. On the positive side, there are opportunities offered by the RTI Act, which make monitoring of public performance easier.

Finally, one should not expect that tackling corruption solely within the public service will work. We need to simultaneously tackle related structural issues—systems of political party financing, government-business networks and inducements for rent-seeking. There is little reason to expect miracles from a single reform such as simplifying the firing of corrupt bureaucrats in a system where many important institutions are compromised. However, it can make some difference. And that difference will matter most for the poor—those who have not yet reaped the gains of 'India shining.'

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